WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital

IVORY COAST

Africa

Information current as of October 2026

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Abidjan	Economic capital and West Africa's leading commercial hub; its port handled a record 46.6 million tonnes in 2025 (+16.1%) and hosts the regional stock exchange (BRVM) and the African Development Bank headquarters	Financial services, port logistics, manufacturing, real estate
San-Pédro	Second deep-water port and principal cocoa export gateway, with an industrial zone of 141 firms and a new commercial court	Cocoa processing, agro-industry, port logistics
Offshore Baleine and Calao (Gulf of Guinea)	Eni-led Baleine Phase 3, approved in May 2026, will raise output from 60,000 to 150,000 barrels a day and gas for the domestic market from 80 to 200 million cubic feet a day	Oil and gas, offshore services, gas-to-power
Cocoa belt (centre-west and south-west)	Heart of the world's largest cocoa industry, supporting around 1.2 million farming households	Cocoa sourcing and processing, traceability, agri-inputs
Akoupé-Zeudji PK24 industrial zone	1,000-hectare zone north of Abidjan; 173 companies have been allocated land, 67 are operational and announced investment totals €875 million	Manufacturing, agro-processing, construction materials
Northern and north-western gold belt	Gold output reached 59 tonnes in 2024, and Montage Gold's Koné mine poured first gold in September 2026	Gold mining, mining services, power and logistics
Grand-Bassam (VITIB free zone)	Dedicated technology and biotechnology free zone near Abidjan for ICT and digital businesses	ICT, digital services, biotechnology

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- CEPICI (Centre de Promotion des Investissements en Côte d'Ivoire), the national investment agency and one-stop shop, which registered 26,948 new companies and approved CFA 812.67 billion of private investment in 2025
- Investment Code (Ordinance No 2018-646, amended in 2019 and 2024) offering equal treatment of foreign and domestic investors, protection against expropriation, and declaration and approval regimes with incentives graded by zone (A, B, C)

- Industrial zones (eleven main zones, including the new Akoupé-Zeudji PK24) and the VITIB technology free zone in Grand-Bassam
- CFA franc (XOF) pegged to the euro and managed by the BCEAO; the Investment Code guarantees access to foreign exchange and profit repatriation, with FDI above 10% reported to the BCEAO and generally no prior authorisation required
- Public-private partnership framework under Law No 2018-575, overseen by the National Steering Committee for PPPs (CNP-PPP)
- Production-sharing contracts with Petroci for hydrocarbons and permits under the Mining Code for gold and other minerals
- OHADA uniform business law, with arbitration through the CCJA or the CACI arbitration centre and commercial courts in Abidjan, Bouaké and San-Pédro

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Ivory Coast in October 2026 stands out as one of Africa's fastest-growing and most creditworthy economies. GDP grew 6.5% in 2025, with the IMF projecting around 6% in 2026 and about 6.7% a year over the medium term. Inflation was close to zero in 2025, the fiscal deficit was brought back to the WAEMU ceiling of 3% of GDP and public debt fell to 57.1% of GDP, its first decline in more than a decade. In June 2026 the IMF completed its $3.5 billion EFF/ECF and $1.3 billion RSF programmes and moved the country to low risk of debt distress, the only sub-Saharan African country with that status. Fitch upgraded the sovereign to BB in December 2025, and a $1.3 billion 15-year Eurobond in February 2026 drew $6.3 billion of orders. FDI reached $3.8 billion in 2024, its highest since 1990, and the 2026–2030 National Development Plan looks to the private sector for 70.2% of $205 billion in planned investment.

The economy's main structural challenge is its reliance on cocoa, where world price swings pass through to farm incomes and public revenues. After setting a record CFA 2,800 per kg, the government reset the farmgate price to CFA 1,200 in March 2026 and held it for the 2026/27 main crop as world prices retreated, while the Middle East conflict since February 2026 has raised fuel and fertiliser costs. Ivory Coast is mitigating this through the Coffee-Cocoa Council's forward-sales system, which gives early price visibility, and through rapid diversification. Baleine Phase 3 will more than double offshore oil output and supply gas to domestic power, Saipem has won contracts worth about $930 million on the project, and new gold mines such as Koné are coming on stream. Combined with record port volumes and expanding industrial zones, this broadening base creates opportunities across energy, mining, agro-processing and logistics.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
Cocoa price volatility	The farmgate price was reset from CFA 2,800 to CFA 1,200 per kg in 2026 after world prices fell, and StoneX forecasts 2026/27 output 11% lower at 1.77 million tonnes	Forward sales provide price visibility; processors and input suppliers can benefit from lower bean costs and replanting needs
Security in the neighbouring Sahel	Rating agencies note spillover risk from Mali and Burkina Faso, while port transit to these markets rose 34.1% in 2025	Commission site-specific security assessments for northern projects; Abidjan's role as the Sahel's gateway continues to grow
Imported energy and food price pressures	The Middle East conflict is lifting fuel and fertiliser costs, with inflation projected at 3.3% in 2026 and a temporary deficit target of 3.8% of GDP	The euro peg, regional reserves above eight months of imports and a commitment to return to 3% by 2028 anchor stability
Informal economy and narrow tax base	Revenue was 16.8% of GDP in 2025, and a large informal sector limits the formal market	Tax modernisation and e-invoicing are levelling the field for formal firms and opening opportunities in fintech and digital services
Governance and administrative processes	Governance indicators are improving but remain below the BB median, according to Fitch	Use CEPICI facilitation, OHADA law and CCJA arbitration; a beneficial ownership register and new commercial courts support transparency

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
EU deforestation and traceability rules	EU deforestation rules are due to apply from end-2026, requiring cocoa supply chains to demonstrate traceability	Build certified, traceable sourcing early; traceability and digital-agriculture services are a growth opportunity
Currency and payment formalities	The CFA franc's euro peg removes euro exchange risk, but dollar exposure and documentation requirements for transfers apply	Hedge dollar revenues and agree transfer documentation with local banks at the outset

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Ivory Coast's risk profile is that of a stable, fast-growing economy with improving public finances and strong market access. The peaceful 2025 presidential election, which Fitch said showed the country has moved beyond its history of election-related unrest, a new government focused on the 2026–2030 National Development Plan, the successful completion of IMF programmes and the move to low risk of debt distress all point to sustained policy continuity. The principal sensitivities are external: cocoa price swings, higher energy and fertiliser costs linked to the Middle East conflict, and security developments in the neighbouring Sahel. These are cushioned by the CFA franc's euro peg, regional reserves above eight months of imports, a fiscal path back to 3% of GDP by 2028 and a diversifying production base in oil, gas and gold. Investors in cocoa-linked businesses should plan for price cycles and EU traceability requirements, while those in northern regions should include standard security assessments.

MARKET ACCESS

Ivory Coast is the largest economy in the West African Economic and Monetary Union (WAEMU), whose eight members share the CFA franc, and a member of ECOWAS, giving tariff-preferential access across the wider West African market. It has been a WTO member since 1995, has ratified the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA) and has an Economic Partnership Agreement with the EU, its main destination for cocoa. Abidjan is the primary sea gateway for landlocked Sahel economies: in 2025 transit through the port reached 2.4 million tonnes to Burkina Faso and 1.47 million tonnes to Mali, served by road and the Abidjan–Ouagadougou railway. Container traffic of almost 1.7 million TEU, a second deep-water port at San-Pédro and growing offshore energy output give the country a strong platform for both regional and global trade.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Presidency of the Republic (Alassane Ouattara)	Re-elected in October 2025; sets national economic strategy, including the 2026–2030 National Development Plan	Primary reference point for Ivory Coast's strategic direction and flagship projects
CEPICI (Centre de Promotion des Investissements en Côte d'Ivoire)	National investment agency and one-stop shop for company formation and Investment Code approvals	Standard first point of contact for market entry and incentive guidance
Central Bank of West African States (BCEAO)	Regional central bank managing the euro-pegged CFA franc; held its policy rate at 3.00% in September 2026	Relevant for currency, banking-sector and capital-transfer matters
Ministry of Economy, Finance and Budget (Adama Coulibaly)	Leads fiscal policy, debt management and relations with the IMF and Eurobond investors	Key interlocutor on fiscal incentives, PPPs and public financing
Ministry of Mines, Petroleum and Energy and Petroci	Regulate and partner in oil, gas, mining and power, including Baleine with Eni and Vitol	Essential counterparts for any energy, mining or power-sector engagement
Coffee-Cocoa Council (Conseil du Café-Cacao)	Regulates the cocoa sector, sets the farmgate price and manages forward sales of the crop	Central counterpart for cocoa sourcing, processing and traceability investment
Ministry of Commerce, Industry and Crafts (Ibrahim Khalil Konaté)	Oversees industrial policy and the development of industrial zones such as	Relevant for manufacturing, agro-processing and industrial land access

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
	Akoupé-Zeudji PK24	

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The Confédération Générale des Entreprises de Côte d'Ivoire (CGECI) is the leading private-sector employers' body and works with CEPICI on investor outreach, including briefings on the Investment Code. The Chamber of Commerce and Industry of Côte d'Ivoire provides business liaison and hosts the CACI arbitration centre. Abidjan is home to the African Development Bank's headquarters and the regional stock exchange (BRVM), and the World Bank Group and IMF maintain active country programmes. International energy and mining companies, including Eni, provide useful practical intelligence on the hydrocarbons and gold sectors, while the major cocoa traders and processors are a valuable channel for agribusiness insight.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Ivory Coast suits investors seeking exposure to a large, stable and diversifying West African economy with a euro-anchored currency: oil, gas and power investors building on the Baleine expansion and domestic gas supply; mining companies and service providers in the growing gold sector; agribusiness and food-processing investors adding value to cocoa and other export crops; logistics and manufacturing investors using Abidjan's port and the new industrial zones to serve WAEMU and Sahel markets; and financial-services and fintech investors drawn by a deepening regional capital market. Cocoa-linked investors should plan for price cycles and EU traceability requirements.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage CEPICI and confirm Investment Code incentives
Open dialogue with the national investment agency to confirm the applicable regime, zone-based incentives and one-stop-shop formalities.

STEP 2: Secure sites in industrial zones or the VITIB free zone
Approach the Ministry of Commerce and Industry and zone managers early to secure serviced land at Akoupé-Zeudji PK24, San-Pédro or Grand-Bassam.

STEP 3: Position for the energy and mining expansion
Engage Petroci, the Ministry of Mines, Petroleum and Energy and operators such as Eni for supply-chain, gas-to-power and mining-services opportunities.

STEP 4: Build price-cycle and traceability planning into cocoa-linked investments
Work with the Coffee-Cocoa Council and certified suppliers to align with forward-sales timing and EU deforestation requirements.

STEP 5: Structure transfers, contracts and dispute resolution at the outset
Agree foreign-exchange documentation with local banks and use OHADA law with CCJA or CACI arbitration clauses.